direct manner, but he vetoed the idea. ‘He was concerned, understood the emotions of the protestors, but didn’t want to create a tamasha by going to India Gate to meet people,’ was the explanation offered. A few days later, he quietly went and met the family of the Delhi braveheart. A few months later, Parliament passed a strong anti-rape legislation.

Should Rahul have been at India Gate expressing solidarity with the protestors? When I asked this question to the home minister Sushil Kumar Shinde in a live television programme, he controversially answered, ‘You cannot expect us to go everywhere to meet protestors. Next you will ask the home minister to go to India Gate if Maoists are demonstrating there!’ A more rational explanation was provided by Shinde’s deputy, R.P.N. Singh, who was tasked with handling the crisis. ‘I don’t think we can reduce a serious issue to a photo op. If Rahul had met the agitators, news channels will get a photo op, but how will anything have changed on the ground?’

Ironically, in February 2014, when a young Arunachal student Nido Tania was beaten to death in mysterious circumstances in a Delhi marketplace, Rahul did go to Jantar Mantar to meet the protestors who were seeking greater security for north-east students. He promised to take up their cause. The incident took place just ahead of the Lok Sabha elections. Nido’s father was a Congress legislator from Arunachal. The timing and context, it seems, were suddenly very different. Opportunistic, the critics alleged, not without justification.

Politics in India is often about symbolism. Indira Gandhi on elephant-back crossing floodwaters to reach the village of Belchi in Bihar, where Dalits had been attacked, became an enduring symbol of her fighting spirit that eventually catapulted her back into power after the Emergency. Had Rahul realized the power of political symbolism, he may well have won the perception war when it really mattered. Had he used either the Anna agitation or the anti-rape protests to mobilize public opinion, he might well have been seen as an intrepid young leader ready to break new ground. The anti-rape protests in Delhi were a defining moment for gender equality that cut across the political divide. The Anna agitation was equally an expression of rising public anger with corruption. Both movements had a